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RE V1 V2 V3 V4



Sunny 55/45 • Tomorrow: Cloudy, rain 56/50 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, APRIL 9, 2025 • **\$4**

Trump's tactics subvert vision of a 'Golden Age'

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

President Donald Trump faces a major obstacle in trying to transform the U.S. economy into a self-reliant colossus: himself.

Building the factories to realize the president's promised high-tariff "Golden Age" and finding the workers to operate them will not be easy. But Trump's use of unilateral presidential authority, rather than congressional legislation, to enact new import taxes, his contradictory policies, and his history of changing course may discourage business executives from even starting.

Since his April 2 high-tariff announcement, Trump and his senior advisers have given con-

flicting signals about whether he intends to use the tariff threat as leverage to win concessions from U.S. trading partners or levy permanent import taxes of up to 50 percent on some countries (and even higher in the case of China).

"They can both be true. There can be permanent tariffs and there can also be negotiations," the president said on Monday as he welcomed Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to the White House.

Trump also has compared his historic tariffs to harsh "medicine" that the economy must endure.

SEE TRUMP ON A13

Tariff deals: White House stresses desire for negotiations. **A15**

Stocks sink despite talk of trade deals

LOSSES PUT S&P 500 NEAR BEAR MARKET

Trump aides detail tariffs to nervous lawmakers

BY DAVID J. LYNCH AND AARON GREGG

The stock market staged a brief rally Tuesday on hopes that President Donald Trump would turn from raising tariffs to cutting deals, before sinking amid renewed tough talk by administration officials. The S&P 500 index closed down 1.5 percent, bringing its total loss since the mid-February start of Trump's trade offensive to almost 20 percent, the offi-

cial indication of a bear market.

Stocks jumped nearly 4 percent in the first hour of trading, after Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent told CNBC that nearly 70 countries had approached the United States about negotiating over trade barriers. The next escalation of U.S. tariffs was just hours away. But the president fueled the upbeat mood with a subsequent social media post, describing a "great call" with South Korea's acting president about a potential bargain.

Yet the market rebound soon

SEE TARIFFS ON A16

Digging in: China thinks it has the upper hand in the trade war. **A14**

U.S. budget: Import taxes could jeopardize "big, beautiful bill." **A16**



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent arrives Tuesday on Capitol Hill, where he sought to calm fears among Republicans.

Producer profits soar along with egg prices

USDA payments to grow even as some big firms charge consumers more

BY PETER WHORISKEY

The avian influenza outbreak has had far-reaching consequences: More than 120 million hens have been slaughtered and egg prices have risen to record levels. In his address to Congress last month, President Donald Trump called the situation "out of control."

Yet for some corporate egg companies, these are good times.

On Tuesday, the nation's largest egg producer, Mississippi-based Cal-Maine, announced quarterly profits of \$509 million, more than three times what it made in the same period a year ago. It caps three years of extraordinary earnings, which have surged since the avian flu outbreak began in 2022.

By wiping out millions of laying hens, the avian flu has slowed egg production for many companies. But the outbreak also has driven up prices enough for some companies to recoup losses and, for Cal-Maine, to record exceptional profits. Cal-Maine's financial reports show it has been able to more than triple its price for a dozen eggs, from about \$1.30 before the outbreak to as high as \$4.06, while its feed costs for producing an egg have been relatively stable.

At the same time, Cal-Maine and other large egg companies have received tens of millions of dollars from the U.S. Department of Agriculture, which has been doling out relief payments to help egg companies restock after the virus strikes.

Cal-Maine, which produces about 20 percent of the nation's egg supply, has benefited from the government program twice. After

SEE EGGS ON A12



PEDRO PARDO/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A rare N. Korean opening slams shut

Hyesan, once a humming trade hub, now typifies Kim's tightening authoritarianism

BY MICHELLE YE HEE LEE

SEOUL — The border city of Hyesan once offered a glimpse of a more open version of totalitarian North Korea. It was flourishing in a way that could almost be called capitalist, and residents could easily learn about the outside world, with China just across a narrow river.

Not anymore. A city that once exuded hope now exemplifies how Kim Jong Un has dramatically expanded his authoritarian controls to erode North Koreans' few freedoms, according to residents of and escapees from Hyesan.

Over the past five years, since the pandemic broke out, Kim has tightened his grip on trade across the border. This has limited ordinary people's ability to make money and attain a level of autonomy from the regime.

"The market system is dead," one Hyesan resident, a woman in her 40s who once operated a wholesale business over the



TOP: A March 2024 photo shows a watchtower on the border in Hyesan, as seen from the Chinese region of Changbai.

border, told The Washington Post through an intermediary. "The government is taking all the profits that those of us making money would have kept."

Kim also used the pretext of the pandemic to put up new barriers — both literally and figuratively — that have isolated Hyesan residents as never before: New fencing stops people from crossing the river. Clampdowns on illicit phone calls made using Chinese cellphone towers have made it much harder for residents to call or text family and friends in China or South Korea, or mindlessly scroll through China's version of TikTok.

These new restrictions are profoundly changing the way North Koreans go about their lives, both in Hyesan, a provincial capital of about 200,000 people, and across the country.

"Hyesan was once a rare opening, but draconian covid-era restrictions have

SEE NORTH KOREA ON A10

Columbia targeted by the right as a 'test case' in education war

BY SUSAN SVRLUGA AND DANIELLE DOUGLAS-GABRIEL

Months before Columbia University interim president Katrina Armstrong stepped down, conservative policy circles were buzzing about ways to force elite universities to change.

Critical of college admissions, diversity, equity and inclusion policies, and campus protests that he lambasted as pro-Hamas,

Max Eden, then a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, wrote an outline that presaged what was to come in the new Trump administration. He singled out Columbia as the top target.

"To scare universities straight," Eden wrote in the Washington Examiner, Education Secretary Linda McMahon "should start by taking a prize scalp. She should simply destroy

Columbia University."

Eden, whose opinion piece came before Trump was inaugurated or McMahon was confirmed, suggested canceling research grants and deporting international students who took part in protests. Though it's unclear whether his plan had a direct impact, it bears a striking resemblance to the early actions the Trump administration has taken to transform America's

most prestigious colleges and universities.

During his campaign, Trump characterized colleges as indoctrinating young people and not doing more to stop antisemitism and protests on campus. "Colleges have gotten hundreds of billions of dollars from hardworking taxpayers and now we are going to get this anti-American insanity out of our institutions once and for all," he said last year.

Columbia quickly became the first front in the higher education war.

Last month, McMahon met with Armstrong and told her that \$400 million in funding to Columbia had been canceled for what the federal government said was the school's failure to protect Jewish students from discrimination. Several international students who the administration

SEE COLUMBIA ON A17

IN THE NEWS

Celestial crossroads As the nominee to lead NASA gets a hearing, the agency must decide which body will be central to its spaceflight mission: the moon or Mars. **A6**

An agent remembered Secret Service members paid their respects to Clint Hill, who dove onto John F. Kennedy's limo in 1963. **B1**

THE NATION **U.S. DOGE Service** cuts at a Florida manatee refuge have been reversed — for now. **A3**
The government ended a civil rights agreement on Native students in South Dakota. **A5**

THE WORLD **France's** Marine Le Pen is borrowing from the populist playbook after her ban from politics. **A7**
The United States' standing among the European public is eroding, polling shows. **A8**

THE ECONOMY **Biotech start-ups** are struggling as the National Institutes of Health reduces or freezes medical research funding. **A11**
In weighing its response to U.S. tariffs, Europe is aiming for consensus and avoiding escalation. **A14**

THE REGION **A California man** pleaded guilty in federal court to plotting to kill Supreme Court Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh. **B1**
Maryland's General Assembly resolved debates over the state budget and other priorities on the last day of its 90-day session. **B1**

STYLE **Grant cuts** by the National Endowment for the Humanities have drawn widespread condemnation. **C1**

FOOD **A century ago**, Frank Pepe fired up a pizza movement in New Haven, Connecticut. It's still going strong. **E1**

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